PHP REGEX

The symbols, the building blocks, and what they mean

PCRE2

READ THIS PATTERN

~^(\w+)\s*=\s*(\d+)$~i

~ delimiters | ^ start | (...) capture | $ end | i ignore case

CHARACTERS

\d	Digit (0-9)
\D	Not a digit
\w	Word character
\W	Not a word character
\s	Space, tab or newline
\S	Not whitespace
.	Any char (usually no newline)
\p{L}	Unicode letter (with u)

HOW MANY?

?	Zero or one
*****	Zero or more
+	One or more
{3}	Exactly three
{2,5}	Between two and five
{2,}	At least two
***?**	Lazy (as few as possible)

SETS & LITERALS

[abc]	One of a, b or c
[a-z]	Lowercase letter range
[^abc]	Anything except a, b, c
\.	A literal dot
\+	A literal plus sign

GROUPS & CHOICES

(abc)	Capture a group
(?:abc)	Group without capture
a|b	Either a or b
(?:a|b)	Group either choice
(?<id>...)	Named capture
\1	Repeat capture group 1
\k<id>	Repeat named capture

LOOKAROUNDS

(?=x)	Must be followed by x
(?!x)	Must NOT be followed by x
(?<=x)	Must be preceded by x
(?<!x)	Must NOT be preceded by x

MODIFIERS (AFTER DELIMITER)

i	Ignore case
m	^ and $ match each line
s	Dot includes newline
u	UTF-8 interpretation
x	Ignore pattern whitespace

POSITIONS

^	Start of subject / line
$	End of subject / line
\b	Word boundary
\A / \z	Absolute start / end